

Muncie City Council September 14, 2026

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4_xDsuh500
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Municipal Meeting Report: Muncie Common Council

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

- **Session Type & Topic:** Public Hearing on Proposed 2027 Budgets (00:01:58)
- **Summary of Discussion:**
 - The council held public hearings for three separate budget ordinances: Ordinance 20-26 (Muncie Indiana Transit System/MITS budget), Ordinance 21-26 (Sanitary District budget), and Ordinance 22-26 (Civil City budget).
 - Public comments during the hearings focused heavily on tax levy increases, employee contract negotiations, and transparency in the budget process.
 - Rick Yenser questioned a 22% levy increase for the transportation district and expressed concern over property and income tax increases.
 - Amanda Price, General Manager of MITS, explained that MITS agreed to a 4% wage increase for 2026 (\$500 lump sum for full-time, \$250 for part-time) and noted a very large increase in health insurance costs while contract negotiations for 2027-2029 remain ongoing.
 - Christopher Bilbury criticized the council's shift away from a 9-person committee to a 3-person finance committee for reviewing the budget, urging the council to maintain transparency and include all members in departmental reviews.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding officer called the regular meeting of the Muncie Common Council to order on September 14, 2026 (00:16:55).
 - **Attendance:**
 - Presiding Officer: Council President Green
 - Members Present: Mr. Dishman, Mr. Macintosh, Mr. Mason, Mr. Garrett, Mr. Basham (and other council members participating/speaking during the session).
 - Members Absent: Not explicitly detailed in roll call, though quorum was established.
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3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:**
 - The Pledge of Allegiance was led by Mr. Dishman (00:17:18).
 - An opening prayer was offered (00:17:34).
 - **Citizen Recognition:** Council recognized Jasmine Taylor as the September Citizen of the Month for her community resilience, work with Habitat for Humanity, Unity Fest, and the Young Entrepreneurship Leadership Academy (00:18:51). Councilman Brandon Garrett also praised community unity during a recent local flood along Buck Creek (00:28:16).
 - **Approval of Minutes:** Minutes from the August 20th special meeting were approved by voice vote (00:32:51).
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

Committee Reports & Presentations

- **Office of Community and Rural Affairs (OCRA):** Molly Marcus presented an overview of the state's Recovery Housing Program, offering grants up to \$750,000 (with a 10% match) for local recovery residences supporting substance abuse treatment (00:38:03).
 - **Beach Grove Cemetery:** Denise King, Board President, provided an operational update highlighting headstone restoration volunteers, iron fence restoration, damage from recent flooding, and upcoming historical tours on October 10th (00:39:51).
 - **Finance Committee Structure Request:** A council member formally requested that President Green reconsider the 3-person finance committee appointments and return to a 9-person committee of the whole for budget deliberations, citing the fiscal weight of recent tax and state legislative changes (00:46:24).
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Ordinances & Resolutions (Introductions & Actions)

- **00:49:26 Ordinance 16-26: Zoning Map Amendment**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Plan Commission (Kylene Swackhammer) / Kathy Vanise (Ashton Land Surveyor).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The presenter noted a clerical error in the paperwork: the property location was incorrectly listed as the *northwest* corner instead of the *southwest* corner of East Rian Road and North Old State Road 3. Council voted to amend the text.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Amended and introduced successfully by voice vote.
- **00:32:57 Ordinance 17-26: Designated Outdoor Refreshment Areas (DORA) Expansion**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Co-sponsored by Council members Sarah and Row / Karly Acree-King (MADJAX Executive Director).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Expands the downtown DORA footprint to incorporate MADJAX and Cornerstone Center for the Arts, as well as nearby establishments like Adam Street Chop House and Culinary Cottage. Discussion ensued regarding neighborhood notifications, boundary markers, and container regulations during special events.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Introduced; passed by voice vote.
- **00:14:09 Ordinance 18-26: Slogan "In God We Trust" on City Vehicles**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Council President Green.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Proposes requiring the slogan "In God We Trust" on all city-owned police and fire vehicles. Public comment featured heavy opposition regarding fiscal priorities (equating decal costs to thousands of dollars that could otherwise support firefighter gear or employee raises) and constitutional concerns regarding the Establishment Clause. Council attorney Brandon Murphy expressed confidence that the slogan aligns with legal standards (similar to state motor vehicle plates and U.S. currency). Several citizens and council members debated the cost and appropriateness of the mandate.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Failed introduction (Roll call vote: Failed).
- **01:48:18 Ordinance 19-26: Salary Ordinance Amendment (Department Restructuring)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Human Resources Director Patty Goddard / Animal Care & Services Director Josh Talby / Building Commissioner representative.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Proposes administrative restructuring in the Building Commissioner's office and Animal Care & Services (combining office manager and rescue coordinator roles into a hybrid position). Union representatives (Nate Burgess and Courtney Walker) and members of the public criticized the changes for shifting positions out of the AFSCME union and creating administrative roles over boots-on-the-ground staff without prior union notification.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion made and seconded to **table** Ordinance 19-26 for further information regarding its effect on union positions (**02:10:04**). Passed by

voice vote.

- **02:11:13 Ordinance 20-26: Proposed 2027 MITS Budget**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Amanda Price, General Manager.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Establishes appropriations and tax rates for the Muncie Indiana Transit System budget for 2027, featuring a 6% levy increase tied to the state maximum levy growth quotient to cover fleet replacements (buses costing over \$721,000 each).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Introduced; approved by voice vote.
 - **02:18:41 Ordinance 21-26: Proposed 2027 Sanitary District Budget**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dina Cox, Financial Manager.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Establishes sanitation appropriations and tax rates for 2027, reflecting a 4% increase driven by wage adjustments and rising waste disposal fees through Best Way.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Introduced; approved by voice vote.
 - **02:43:34 Ordinance 22-26: Proposed 2027 Civil City Budget**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** City Controller Matt Waggley / Councilman Basham.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Controller Waggley discussed the filing of the 2027 civil budget amidst staffing transitions following the passing of former controller Craig Wright. Councilman Basham announced upcoming finance committee meeting dates (Sept 22, Sept 24, Sept 30 at 6:00 PM). Public and council members heavily criticized the continued utilization of a 3-person finance committee rather than a committee of the whole.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Introduced; approved by voice vote.
 - **02:54:51 Resolution 13-26: Investigation into Professional Services Contract (George Jeffrey How)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sponsored by Council members including Councilperson Goian.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Directs an inquiry into the original professional services contract and subsequent addendums between the city and George Jeffrey How, compliance with Board of Works approval processes, open door law requirements during July meetings, and compensation details.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Failed by voice vote / roll call (Defeated).
 - **03:00:56 Resolution 14-26: Memorial Resolution for Craig Wright**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** City Council.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** A memorial resolution honoring and remembering City Controller Craig Wright, with council members sharing personal recollections of his professional dedication, kindness, and love for baseball.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Passed Unanimously by Voice Vote.
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5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **03:06:36 Rick Yenser:** Addressed surveillance spending (flock cameras and drones) versus rising crime rates and community safety concerns.
- **03:08:02 Christopher Bilbury:** Criticized council decorum enforcement, lack of transparency regarding council committee structures, and the handling of professional service contract votes.
- **03:11:42 Lyn Thornberg:** Highlighted upcoming community events, including the Washington Street bridge dinner and the 50th Old Washington Street Festival, reflecting on the community strength demonstrated during historical crises.
- **03:14:03 Chip Taylor:** Spoke on the municipal budget process, structural limitations on public input, and the need for greater transparency between the mayoral administration and city council.
- **03:17:48 Missy Barton:** Raised questions regarding job descriptions, city employee processes, and expressed disappointment regarding deteriorating physical conditions (weeds, roads) in the city.
- **03:21:01 Elizabeth Edgel:** Discussed concerns over automated license plate reader (flock camera) data privacy, public trust issues, and contradictions in administrative statements.
- **03:24:45 Judith Hill:** Addressed council party affiliation switches, meeting lengths, and tax abatement tracking for local businesses.
- **03:28:23 Wayne Skay:** Voiced disappointment regarding consistency in council votes, religious slogans, and political alignment.
- **03:31:28 Rodney Vaughn:** Addressed neighborhood representation by council members and expressed concerns over political party switches.
- **03:33:12 Daisy Dale:** Promoted an upcoming historical presentation at the Carnegie Library on October 1st regarding the Ku Klux Klan and historical legal battles in Muncie.
- **03:34:33 Padre Campbell:** Shared personal testimony regarding a 73-day period without running water at her residence, raising serious accountability concerns regarding local housing authority officials, health department inspectors, and pending litigation.
- **03:37:58 Jason Denetti:** Highlighted severe debris and safety issues at Westside Park following recent flooding, promoted the upcoming White River Cleanup on Saturday, and asked for transparency regarding urban forestry grant programs.
- **03:45:26 Nate Burgess:** Spoke regarding union negotiation records and offered collaborative outreach to council members.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - Finance Committee budget review sessions scheduled for September 22, September 24, and September 30, 2026, at 6:00 PM in the City Hall Auditorium.

- White River Cleanup event scheduled for the upcoming Saturday at Westside Park.
 - **Adjournment:** The meeting was officially adjourned following a motion and second (03:47:39).
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